

Suggest and recommend

Learner workbook

Offer an idea using a natural verb pattern.

Understand the distinction

Use suggest or recommend with a noun or an -ing activity: suggest a cafe; recommend booking early. With a named person doing the action, a that clause is useful: I suggest that she book early. She should book is also possible after that, especially in British English.

Do not use suggest someone to do for advice. Say suggest that someone do, or suggest doing. Recommend has additional patterns and meanings, such as recommend someone for a job. Learn the meaning and pattern together instead of treating both verbs as identical in every use.

Compare the patterns

ACTIVITY

I recommend booking ahead.

Booking is the suggested activity.

PERSON + ACTION

I suggest that Mina call first.

Use the base verb call in this advice pattern.

RECIPIENT

She suggested a cafe to me.

To me identifies the recipient of the suggestion.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Correct this: She suggested me to apply.

2. Complete: I recommend ___ early. (arrive)

3. Is I suggest that she should call possible?

Use it in your own life

Suggest a practical action to a friend.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. She suggested that I apply.

Suggest does not use the person + to-infinitive advice pattern.

2. arriving

Use an -ing form for the activity.

3. Yes, especially in British English.

Should + base verb is an accepted alternative.

One possible response

I suggest taking an earlier train so you have time to find the office.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-17.html